Revision Date:
January 1, 2026

Background:
Customers approved for Medi-Cal benefits will receive a Benefit Identification Card (BIC) and a Managed Care Plan (MCP) card to obtain medical services.

Purpose:
This section explains how Medi-Cal customers use their cards. This section has been reformatted as part of sunset review. There are no policy changes.

Policy:
There are two benefit delivery systems available to Medi-Cal eligible customers: Managed Care and Fee-for Service (FFS).

Managed Care
Most Medi-Cal customers are required to enroll in Managed Care. The Medi-Cal Choice packet is sent to households when benefits are approved. It provides an explanation of options and information about available MCPs which are assigned based on the customer's zip code. MCPs only serve specific geographic areas. Customers enrolled in MCPs are issued identification cards by their plan. To obtain medical services, the customer presents the MCP card to a provider in that plan. In emergency circumstances, the card can be presented to non-plan providers, who then bill the MCP. MCP customers may also be entitled to other Medi-Cal benefits. For example, because MCPs do not provide dental services, customers will also receive a Medi-Cal BIC for dental services.

Customers may waive mandatory enrollment in an MCP if they meet an exemption. To request waiving mandatory enrollment, the customer must have their physician complete the Medical Exemption Request (MER) and submit it to Health Care Options (HCO). The MER form can be found in the Medi-Cal Choice Packet.

FFS
Some Medi-Cal only customers may receive benefits through FFS, as they cannot enroll in an MCP, or when they are in a voluntary aid code and choose not to enroll. Customers may not be required to enroll if they:

- Receive health services from an Indian Health Provider
- Are in the third trimester of pregnancy
- Are a member who gets assistance under Foster Care, the Adoption Assistance Program, or Child Protective Services
- Live in a California Veteran's Home
- Are being treated for a complex medical condition such as:
  - Pregnancy
  - Cancer
  - Renal disease and have dialysis at least two times a week
  - A disease that affects more than one organ system, such as diabetes
  - Are HIV positive
  - Have conditions that may qualify

Refer customers to HCO to obtain more information on FFS.

BICs

Medi-Cal BICs are issued by the state and are valid in any California county. They may only be used outside of California for emergency services. To obtain medical services, customers present their BIC to any Medi-Cal provider of their choice. The BIC serves as authorization for payment of claims for covered medical services that are:

- Incurred during the month in which the Medi-Cal card is valid
- Not paid for or obligated by the customer to meet the share of cost (SOC) requirement
- Not provided by any Health Care Plan (HCP) of which the customer is a member
- Not payable by a third party under contractual or other legal entitlement
- Not prohibited due to the limited-service status of the customer

Each Medi-Cal customer is required to sign and date their own Medi-Cal BIC in the space provided upon receipt of the card and before it is presented to a provider. Customers who can only make a mark (X) in place of a signature must do so. This requirement does not apply to customers who are:

- Under 18 years of age
- In Long Term Care (LTC)
- Determined by the provider to be unable to sign the card because of disability

A mother's BIC can be used as an authorization for services for her newborn child, during the month of birth and the following month.

It is a misdemeanor for a customer to sell, furnish, give/lend their BIC to any other person(s) for their use.

Limited-Service Delivery System

Certain customers have limits on services covered by Medi-Cal. The Medi-Cal record in the Medi-Cal Eligibility Data System (MEDS) will have restrictions based on either their aid code or special coding which indicates any restrictions on their use of the cards. Examples of limited-service status include:

Restriction	Description
Minor Consent Services	Can only be used for services connected to the minor consent situation.
Managed Care	Can only be used for services covered by the MCP.
Program Abuse	Restriction code applied for customers identified as having a high drug usage pattern or a high Medi-Cal visit pattern. Limits are placed on the amount of services available.
Postpartum (Aid Code 76)	This aid code covers full scope eligibility during pregnancy and the 12-month postpartum period.
Special Treatment Programs	Dialysis and Total Parenteral Nutrition (TPN) aid codes only cover services in these programs.

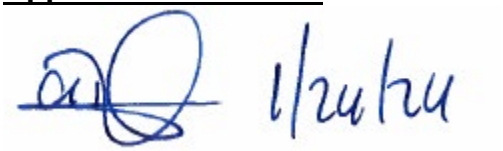
Restriction	Description
Hospice Services	Services are used to treat the symptoms of terminal illness in lieu of curative or life-extending care. Hospice care is oriented towards meeting the needs of patients and their families who are coping with the later stages of terminal illness. Medi-Cal can be used for all other non-terminal diagnosis related health care.
Restricted Benefits	These aid codes for otherwise eligible Omnibus Budget Reconciliation Act (OBRA) non-citizens only cover emergency and pregnancy-related services.
Qualified Medicare Beneficiary (QMB)	QMB-only customer records will be coded to cover only Medicare deductibles and co-insurance. Dually eligible customers will have both the QMB and their regular aid code in MEDS.
Long-Term Care (LTC) (Aid Code 53)	This aid code can only be used for services received while the customer is residing in an LTC facility. The provider system shows the following message, “Services to acute hospital inpatients are not covered.”

Program Impacts:
None.

References:
Medi-Cal Eligibility Procedures Manual (MEPM) 19C.
All County Welfare Directors Letters (ACWDLs) 88-42, 89-80, and 94-07.

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by December 31, 2029.

Approval for Release:



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